

A minimalist illustration of a child with dark hair and rosy cheeks, wearing an orange shirt, sitting on a grey stone bench. To the left is a green bush. The background is a light blue sky with two white oval shapes and a green grassy field at the bottom.

THE LITTLE REWRITES

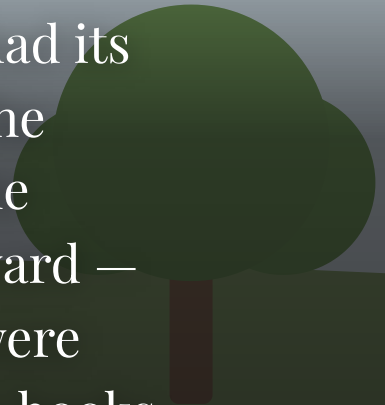
THE ONE WHO SAT ALONE

A story about the new kid, the empty seat, and who we get to become.

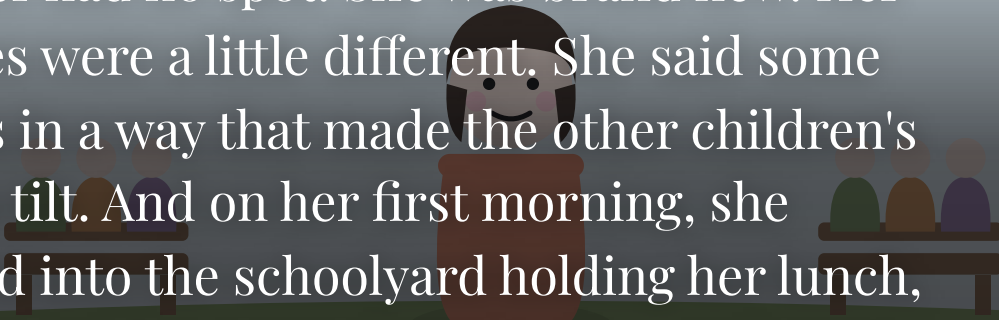
MK PARRISH

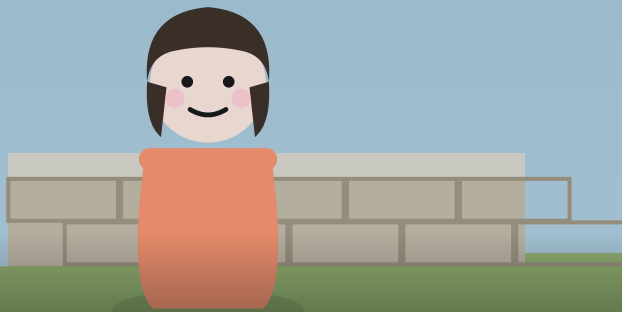


When Juniper moved to the town of Elmsworth, everything there already had its place. The birds had their branches. The shopkeepers had their corners. And the children had their spots in the schoolyard — the same spots they'd had since they were small, sorted and settled and sure, like books on a well-loved shelf.



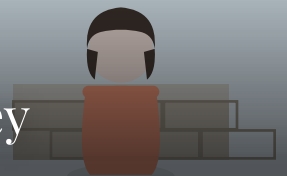
Juniper had no spot. She was brand new. Her clothes were a little different. She said some words in a way that made the other children's heads tilt. And on her first morning, she walked into the schoolyard holding her lunch, and looked for somewhere to sit — and every bench was already full of children who had known each other their whole lives.





So Juniper sat alone, on the low stone wall at the very edge of the yard, and ate her lunch, and looked like she didn't mind. She minded terribly.

The children of Elmsworth were not cruel.
They didn't say mean things or push her. They
just... didn't make room. It's easier not to.
When your shelf is already full and settled, it's
easier to leave the new book on the floor than
to shift everything over to fit it in.

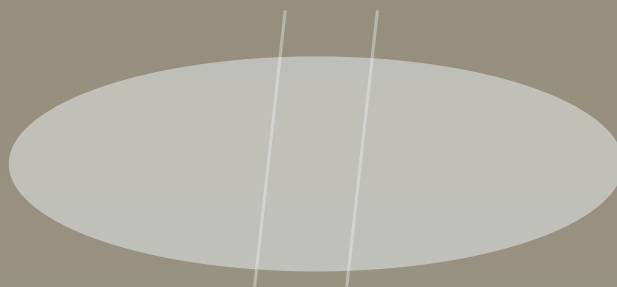




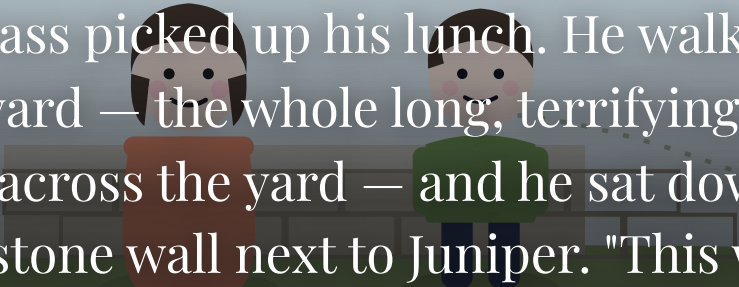
And slowly, the story Juniper told about herself began to change shape, the way sad thoughts do, until it became: *maybe there is something wrong with me. Maybe I am the kind of person who sits alone.* That is the most dangerous part of sitting alone. It isn't the empty seat. It's the story you start to believe about why it's empty.

Among the children there was a boy named Cass. He was not the bravest or the most popular. But Cass had noticed the new girl on the wall — the first day, and the second, and the third. Because Cass had a secret the others had forgotten: he had been the new kid once, too. And he remembered exactly what the low stone wall felt like.

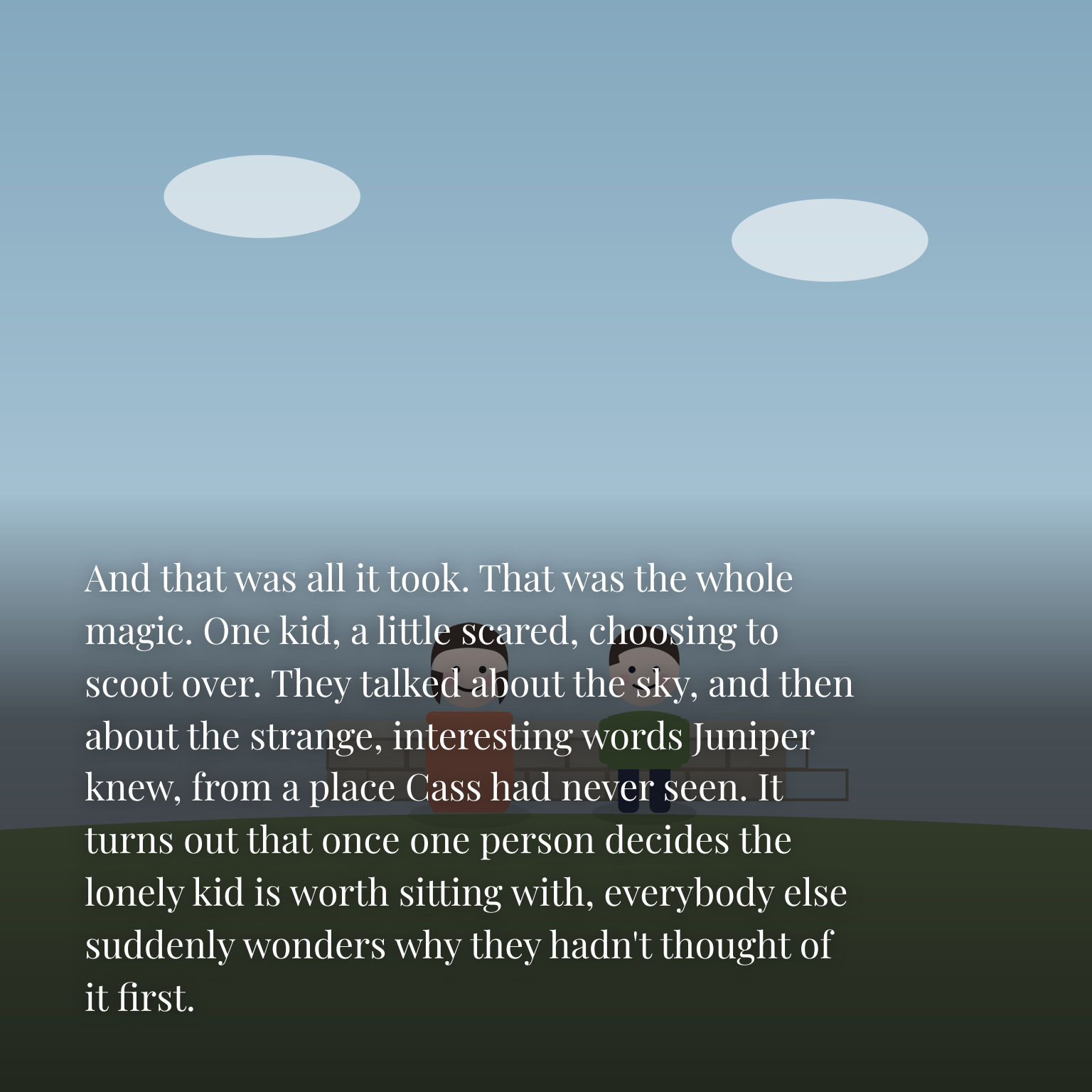




For a whole week, Cass did nothing, because doing something felt enormous and scary. What if he walked over and she didn't want him there? The wall was only a few steps away, but it might as well have been across the sea. And then one grey Thursday, Cass decided that being a little scared was a much smaller thing than letting someone believe they were the kind of person who sits alone.



So Cass picked up his lunch. He walked across the yard — the whole long, terrifying, ordinary way across the yard — and he sat down on the low stone wall next to Juniper. "This wall's better than the benches, honestly," said Cass. "You can see the whole sky from here." "You can," said Juniper, hardly daring to believe it. "I noticed that too."

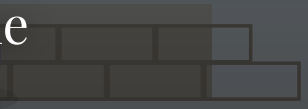
The background of the slide features a blue sky with two large, white, oval shapes. At the bottom, a dark green ground line is visible. In the center, two stylized children are sitting on a brown bench. The child on the left has dark skin and is wearing a red shirt. The child on the right has light skin and is wearing a green shirt. They are both looking towards the text.

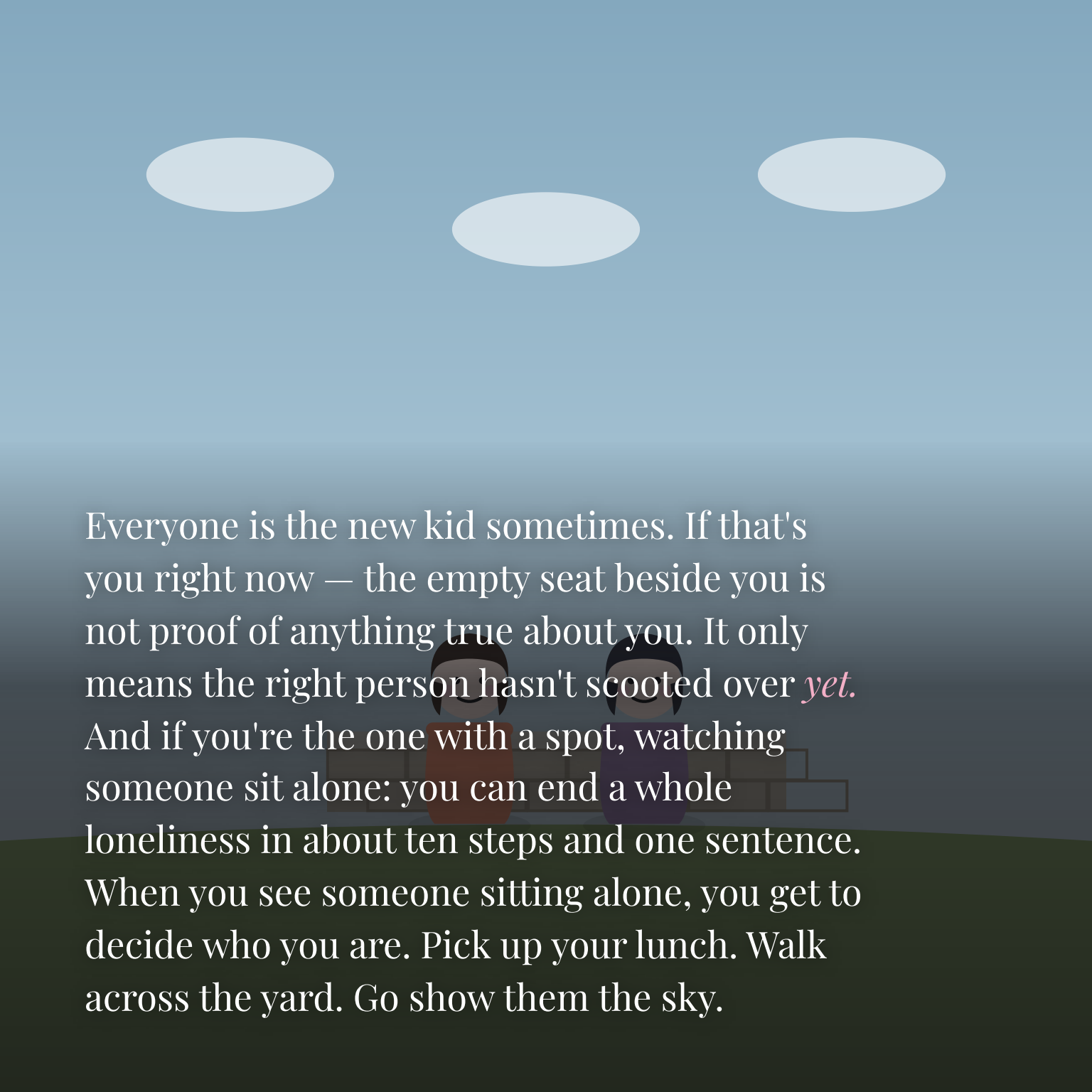
And that was all it took. That was the whole magic. One kid, a little scared, choosing to scoot over. They talked about the sky, and then about the strange, interesting words Juniper knew, from a place Cass had never seen. It turns out that once one person decides the lonely kid is worth sitting with, everybody else suddenly wonders why they hadn't thought of it first.

An illustration of four children sitting on a low stone wall. From left to right, they are wearing a red shirt, a green shirt, a yellow shirt, and a blue shirt. They are all looking forward. The background is a light blue sky with a dark green ground at the bottom.

Within a month, the low stone wall at the edge of the yard — the loneliest spot in all of Elmsworth — had somehow become the *best* spot. The spot where the most interesting talk happened. And it had happened not because Juniper changed to fit the town, but because one ordinary boy changed the town to fit *her*.

The next year, another new child arrived — small, unsure, clutching a lunch, heading for the low stone wall. And Juniper did not wait a whole week. She did not wait a single day. She picked up her lunch, walked across the yard, and sat right down. "This wall's the best spot in the whole school," Juniper said. "You can see the entire sky from here. Want me to show you?"



The background is a blue gradient sky with three white ovals. At the bottom, two stylized figures are sitting on a bench. The figure on the left is wearing a red shirt, and the figure on the right is wearing a purple shirt. They are both looking towards the right. The ground is a dark green gradient.

Everyone is the new kid sometimes. If that's you right now — the empty seat beside you is not proof of anything true about you. It only means the right person hasn't scooted over *yet*. And if you're the one with a spot, watching someone sit alone: you can end a whole loneliness in about ten steps and one sentence. When you see someone sitting alone, you get to decide who you are. Pick up your lunch. Walk across the yard. Go show them the sky.

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

Almost every child, at some point, is the one who sits alone — the new kid, the one who looks or sounds different, the one at the edge of the playground trying to look like they don't mind. This story is for that child, and just as much for the ones who get to decide what happens next. When you finish, ask the child beside you the question the whole book is really about: when you see someone sitting alone, who do you want to be?